

MONHEGAN ISLAND

By Linda Leavell

“Water in motion is far
from level,” said the poet who
brought me here.

I climb Ambrose’s hill and see his
“not-native books and hat,” his
view of the harbor, and keep
going until the fir trees, each
with their “emerald turkey foot,”
mark the edge of the sea.

No one ushers me down the
narrow, unimproved steps
to the granite nook in the cliff
where I find my seat—
protected from the afternoon sun, my neighbors
anonymous insects and tufts
of grass. Below me, the gulls
on their blacker rocks raucously mock
my long absence.

Their tickets to
this “drama of water against
rock” never expire. I come
only for the matinee.

Impossible to paint or
film, the surf pounds the glacier-cut
rocks that won’t be subdued
into roundness or sand. No victors here.
The rising green waves cover
the rocks with their
whiteness, their churning swirl, and then
succumb to the pull of the next
swell. Endlessly different but
unchanged for millennia.

Here at the inner wrist of
the earth, I feel
its pulse.